COUNTRY REPORTS: MAURITANIA

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Status report

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Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Mauritania's governance improvement has all but stopped: it scored 42.5 of 100 for overall governance in 2023, 41st of 54 African states and below the continental average of 49.3, and where the decade to 2023 brought 4.1 points, the most recent five years brought 0.7.

Policy itself is not the missing piece. The National Digital Transformation Agenda 2022–2025 is the governing strategy, with a public-administration pillar making interoperability and a national government cloud and intranet explicit objectives, and headline targets to double internet usage and triple digital-economy employment. Around it sit a national strategy for open and interoperable data built on three axes — an interoperability framework across government, open-data governance aligned with Open Government Partnership principles, and open data for innovation — a 68-page IPv6 transition strategy targeting 25% migration by 2026 and run by a national IPv6 committee the strategy provides for, and a national artificial intelligence strategy published in 2024.

The state's digital agency was designed with outside help. UNDP handed the government a costed design for ANETA, a standing state digital agency under the digital ministry, on 31 July 2021, at around 50 staff, EUR 220,000 to establish and EUR 1.4 million a year to run, with an e-Cabinet platform and a public-procurement portal among its proposed quick wins. Capability has since come sector by sector, from the Ijraati procedures portal to a national e-health strategy.

The ambitions outrun the evidence behind them. The digital ministry presents wide IPv6 adoption as a foundation for the planned wide 5G rollout and for cloud, IoT and AI services (July 2026), while the sector-by-sector economic-impact figures in its own IPv6 strategy are lifted from a 2022 consultancy report rather than measured for Mauritania. At a workshop on blockchain in public administration on 27 July 2026, UNDP's representative argued that any real transformation begins with a change in public governance, which only high-quality data make possible. The Council of Ministers took a statement in September 2026 proposing a framework that would set an access threshold of 16 for social media and switch off recommendation algorithms for minors by default.

Legislation and regulation

Mauritania's Council of Ministers approved on 29 July 2026 a draft decree repealing and replacing the 2020 decree governing the universal-access fund, the instrument that has governed the fund since November 2020.

The digital statute book is longer than it was. Décret n° 2022-009 governs electronic exchanges between users and administrations and between administrations themselves, made under the electronic transactions law of 2018, Loi n° 2021-005 of 10 February 2021 amends the Commercial Code and carries the trade register and the movable securities regime, Loi n° 2025-011 of 24 February 2025 repeals and replaces provisions of the 2011 Civil Status

Code, and Loi n° 2025-006 of 19 February 2025 carries the investment code, its application decree of August 2025 providing for a single window. Two bills are in train: one on access to and use of public information, under discussion since April 2026, and one on the national archives, adopted by the Council of Ministers in March 2026. The older core is short. Law No. 2016-007 is the cybercrime statute, and Law No. 2017-020 of 22 July 2017 on the protection of personal data covers processing by public and private bodies, created the national data protection regulator and establishes rights of access, rectification, erasure and objection — but it has still not been brought fully into force, and no dedicated cross-government data-sharing law is in effect (2024).

Most of what governs digital administration is made by decree rather than by parliament. Inter-administration electronic exchange rests on Décret n° 2022-009, and Décret n° 2021-138 of 3 August 2021 governs the secure chip national identity card, making it the official document establishing identity and nationality, voluntary from age six and compulsory from sixteen for anyone holding a National Identification Number. No dedicated digital-identity legislation has been enacted at all, the digital ID resting on decree and on civil-registration law.

The one recent digital statute is loi n° 2024-002 P.R on technology and innovative start-ups, promulgated on 2 January 2024. The sponsoring ministry's own page names and dates the law but carries no text of it, so what was enacted cannot be read where the government announces it — the same pattern as the universal-access decree, whose replacement terms were not reproduced in the communiqué announcing it.

Data protection

Nine years after it was passed, Mauritania's personal data protection law has still not been brought fully into force, and doing so is the first priority of the data protection authority's 2023–2026 strategic plan.

Law No. 2017-020 of 22 July 2017 covers processing by public and private bodies and created the Autorité de Protection des Données à caractère Personnel as national regulator, and data subjects hold rights of access, rectification, erasure and objection under it; the authority's composition and functioning are set by a decree of 18 February 2022. The authority is a working institution rather than a paper one: it maintains its own institutional site, with an activity stream running to May 2026. The authority has begun issuing under the law: deliberation 004/2025 sets the conditions and procedural rules for transferring personal data abroad, with a list of countries treated as adequate, and deliberation 005/2025, in the amended text published on 30 April 2026, requires public and private bodies using cloud services abroad to obtain prior authorisation for the processing, a separate transfer authorisation where the host country is not on the approved list, and contractual guarantees covering compliance with the 2017 law, return of the data on contract expiry and its permanent deletion by the provider thereafter. It meets monthly: its sessions have approved an inspection reference framework and the qualification of its sworn agents for inspection missions, given a conditional opinion on interconnecting the Maadeni mining information system with the national population register, and taken up the hosting of the state digital agency's data and the accreditation of the Nouakchott data centre. On transfers, no general legal data-localisation requirement applies (2026) — the law restricts cross-border transfers to jurisdictions offering adequate protection, and the national cloud is a sovereignty initiative rather than a localisation mandate.

The direction of travel on the rights the law would protect is the other way. Digital freedom fell 20.3 points over 2014–2023 to 40.0 of 100, 36th of 54 African states and the second most deteriorated of the 96 measures in the index. Protection is also limited by how records are kept at the point personal data is first taken: the UN Human Rights Committee noted in 2021 that police records of detainees were poorly maintained (2023).

Regional collaboration

Mauritania stands outside almost every regional digital instrument in West Africa. When fifteen states adopted the Model Policy Framework for Information Integrity in West Africa and the Sahel at Praia on 5 September 2025, Mauritania was not among the signatories.

The pattern follows from membership. The region's binding data-protection instrument, the ECOWAS Supplementary Act adopted at Abuja on 16 February 2010, covers by its own terms processing carried out in a UEMOA or an ECOWAS member state, a perimeter that belonging to neither union leaves Mauritania outside. The same line runs through payments and connectivity: the BCEAO's instant-payment platform opened in September 2025 with participants from the eight WAEMU states alone, no Mauritanian participation appears in the pan-African instant payment network as at June 2026, and the ECOWAS roaming regulation binds member states, while the reduced-cost community roaming launched in April 2026 runs between Senegal, Togo and Benin. Cross-border identity work is arranged the same way: the regional unique-identification programme runs across six ECOWAS states, Mauritania not among them.

What does bind is continental rather than regional: Mauritania has ratified the African Union's Malabo Convention on cyber security and personal data protection, which with national law carries the whole of its data-protection position. The one substantial regional vehicle that does reach it is financing rather than rulemaking — it is one of four country beneficiaries of the World Bank's Western Africa Regional Digital Integration Program, with the digital transformation ministry as implementing agency. On the voluntary side it is not a member of the Open Government Partnership, where the three comparators its own open-data strategy measures itself against all are.

Standards

Every licensed telecommunications operator in Mauritania had activated IPv6 by July 2026, the furthest any technical standards commitment has been carried. The national transition strategy sets 25% migration by 2026 across a three-phase roadmap of preparation, dual-stack operation and continuous monitoring, and the digital ministry frames wide adoption as a foundation for the planned wide 5G rollout and for cloud, IoT and AI services.

Standards for services rather than for networks are further back. In March 2025 the government held a national workshop, with German cooperation, to set unified standards for digital public services, explicitly to improve interoperability between government systems, and on 28 September 2026 the digital ministry began training its officials and 120 new staff to apply the unified standards to every new digital service. A 2024 scoping study for the digital ministry sets out a general interoperability framework and an interoperability hub — API gateway, identity and access management, a unified data repository — and names civil-status and identity documents as one of the first service families to be brought into it. The legal footing is thinner than the design work: electronic exchange between administrations rests on the 2022 decree, with the general interoperability framework proposed rather than in place (June 2023). The national standards office is Mauritania's ISO correspondent member, participating in five technical committees and observing ten (October 2026).

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Mauritania ranks 5th of 54 African states for media freedom, at 73.8 of 100 in 2023 after a 10.6-point gain over the decade — and 41st of 54 for accountability and transparency, its worst governance dimension at 22.6, and 41st again for freedom of expression and belief at 38.4, down 2.5 points over the same decade. A free-ish press coexists with a state that discloses little and an online space that is the second most deteriorated measure in the whole index. The police Cybercrime Unit arrested two opposition members of parliament on 9 and 10 April 2026 under the 2021 law

on national symbols, over online videos criticising the President, after a news site was shut down in August 2025 on a complaint from the media regulator and a journalist was held in October 2025 over a Facebook call for peaceful protests.

What the state publishes is what limits debate. Disclosure of public records is among the country's ten worst measures, and Mauritania is not a member of the Open Government Partnership whose principles its own open-data strategy invokes. Against that, rural representation and participation rose sharply over 2014–2023 and is now among the country's best-scoring measures.

Consultation on digital policy happens where the sponsoring ministry organises it: the consultation run alongside drafting of the Startup Act found most respondents rating the existing regulatory framework poorly and the draft bill's provisions well (September 2023). Scrutiny after the fact runs through the Inspection Générale d'État, which put the financial impact of irregularities found in its 2024–2025 exercises at over two billion ouguiyas against more than thirty billion audited, stated as recovered, and whose unquantified findings ran to internal-control failures, fictitious competition and unjustified direct awards, with public procurement named the domain most exposed to risk (August 2026).

Finance

Financial sustainability

World Bank lending carries more of Mauritania's digital lines in 2026: the revised 2026 finance law carries MRU 209 million of IDA loan for the regional digital integration programme WARDIP and MRU 150 million for the regional statistics harmonisation project (FY2026), against MRU 75 million and MRU 80 million in the revised 2025 law (FY2025).

The domestic-state share of the digital lines of the revised 2026 finance law is 73.5% at the revised stage, down from 87.5% in 2025 (FY2026).

The lines that keep systems running are the state's own. The revised 2026 law pays MRU 82.5 million for Microsoft licences, voted at MRU 105 million, and MRU 68.7 million for running the national registry agency ANRPTS from domestic funds, and MRU 40 million for maintaining the customs information system from a special treasury account whose receipts it does not name (FY2026). The state's counterpart to the EIB-financed second submarine cable was cut in the 2026 revision from MRU 64.9 million voted to MRU 23.9 million (FY2026).

What the state has in law is the universal-access fund, now being brought onto the budget. Article 6 of the revised 2026 finance law creates a special allocation account under the digital ministry, financed from the sectoral universal-access account up to its 2026 ceiling and confined to universal access to electronic communications, after the Council of Ministers named the lack of a clear framework for folding the fund into the state's budget and accounts among its grounds for replacing the fund's 2020 decree in July 2026. The fund's line stood at MRU 233.8 million in the 2026 budget (FY2026), after the 2025 revision took it from MRU 233.8 million to MRU 834.8 million (FY2025).

The newest shared platform was built with outside money: the digital minister credited the World Bank's WARDIP programme for the national cloud inaugurated on 29 June 2026, and no storage capacity, migration timeline or total cost was disclosed at its launch.

MoUs and other agreements

No digital-sector memorandum of understanding or comparable cooperation agreement had been made public as at September 2026.

New investments

The project connecting Mauritania to the EllaLink submarine cable was launched at Nouadhibou in July 2025, to link the country directly to networks in Europe and the Americas on European Investment Bank financing with European Union support. The EIB had earlier signed a EUR 25 million loan in December 2020 for the first direct high-speed link to Europe and West Africa. Mauritania is also a landing country of the MEDUSA system, backed by a EUR 38.5 million EIB loan and a EUR 40 million European Union grant, and one of eight landing points on Maroc Telecom's EUR 150 million West Africa cable, whose northern segment became operational in April 2022.

The largest commitment made to Mauritania in its own right is an IDA credit of SDR 45.7 million, US$60 million equivalent, appraised in November 2023 under the World Bank's Western Africa Regional Digital Integration Program, of which Mauritania is one of only four country beneficiaries alongside The Gambia, Guinea and Guinea-Bissau. An earlier US$30 million development policy operation supporting private-sector digital reform ran 2021-2022 and is closed.

Germany's BMZ is funding a EUR 4 million digital transformation programme running 2024 to 2027; a EUR 2.5 million French development agency grant channelled through UN Women is modernising the statistics institutes of Mauritania, Senegal and Chad; and China granted MRU 629.4 million in 2021 for an urban security and monitoring system for the national security directorate in Nouakchott, 316 cameras extensible to 1,000 observation points. Mauritania and the Islamic Development Bank agreed in principle in April 2026 on a digital package of around US$50 million covering infrastructure, cybersecurity and skills.

Eleven commitments are on record across 2019 to 2028, eight naming Mauritania as the recipient and three regional operations naming it as a beneficiary. Connectivity takes six of them and about three-quarters of the money; nothing funds digital identity, digital payments or government service delivery. The World Bank and the European Investment Bank are the most frequent financiers, three commitments each, the EIB's all submarine cable. Loans rather than grants carry the money in; the grants fund policy support, statistics and a surveillance system.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Mauritania got its first fifth-generation mobile network on 10 August 2026, when Chinguitel switched it on at a Nouakchott ceremony attended by the digital transformation minister. The operator that took the country there is not a national champion: Chinguitel is a subsidiary of Sudan's Sudatel Group and has operated since it entered the market in 2007, and it set out alongside the launch a 2027–2030 investment plan covering coverage expansion, transport and fibre networks, and national data centres.

Domestic traffic began staying in the country the year before. The national Internet Exchange Point was officially launched in May 2025, hosted at International Mauritanian Telecommunications in Nouakchott and run jointly by government and the operators, though participation remains limited to the IMT consortium and the three national operators. Every licensed operator had activated IPv6 by July 2026, under a ministry strategy that presents wide adoption as a foundation for 5G, cloud and AI services; moving subscribers is the slower half of the job, and as at July 2026 one operator had moved more than 15% of its subscribers, against a national target of 25% by the end of the year.

Reach is the constraint the new equipment does not resolve. 37.4% of individuals used the internet in 2023, against about 113 mobile cellular subscriptions per 100 people in 2022. Quality is: a regulator re-inspection reported on 9 October 2026 found all three mobile operators still breaching their licence obligations on voice and data after the

deadline to comply had passed. Price is not the obvious culprit at the entry level: a 1GB mobile basket cost 1.47% of GNI per capita in 2025, inside the UN Broadband Commission's affordability threshold, while 5GB cost 2.94% and fixed broadband around 17.6%.

The long view is of a mobile network improving fast from a low start while everything around it does not. Mobile communications rose 17.0 points over 2014-2023 to 56.0 of 100 in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, one of Mauritania's ten most improved measures, yet still 43rd of 54 African states, while access to the internet and to computers reached only 24.4 of 100, 38th of 54, on a gain of 5.5 points over the same decade. Infrastructure overall scores 33.3 of 100, 35th of 54.

Data Storage

Mauritania launched a national government cloud on 29 June 2026, giving government agencies shared computing and storage and holding public data inside national borders, with no migration timeline announced. It runs on hardware barely a year old: the National Data Centre in Nouakchott was inaugurated in May 2025, financed by a EUR 15 million European Investment Bank loan, certified Tier III by the Uptime Institute and operated by International Mauritanian Telecommunications. It runs to 1,372 m2 and a capacity of 100 server racks, stated as extensible.

Keeping data in the country is a policy choice rather than a legal duty. No general data-localisation requirement applies, and the 2026 cloud is a sovereignty initiative rather than a mandate, which leaves private and commercial workloads where they were: Amazon Web Services operates no region in Mauritania. The one announced addition to domestic capacity comes from an operator rather than the state, with national data centres named among Chinguitel's 2027–2030 investments.

Energy

Half of Mauritania has mains electricity: 50.3% of the population had access in 2023, a national figure that conceals an almost wholly urban supply, since 93.5% of the urban population had access in the same year. Against the rest of the country's infrastructure record that is a relative strength: access to energy scores 47.2 of 100 in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 21st of 54 African states and up 7.4 points over 2014-2023, Mauritania's best infrastructure measure after mobile communications.

Generation leans unusually hard on renewables, with hydro, wind and solar together supplying close to half of electricity output in 2024. Reliability is the weaker point for anything that has to stay powered: firms reported several outages in a typical month when the measure was last taken, in 2014. The electricity company sought quotations in April 2024 to connect the national data centre to two 4 x 800 kVA delivery substations.

Technical Capacity

Mauritania's own reading of what limits its networks is people rather than equipment: the national IPv6 strategy weights its costing to human resources on the stated ground that most installed equipment already supports the protocol, and the transition is run by a national IPv6 committee the strategy provides for.

The administration doing this work is middling by African comparison and improving: effective administration scores 45.1 of 100 in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 36th of 54 African states, having gained 8.8 points over 2014-2023.

A single body for digital delivery was designed with outside help. UNDP delivered a costed proposal in July 2021, at the government's own request, for a standing state digital agency constituted under the digital ministry, and the national data strategy proposes revising the decree that created the Agence Numérique de l'État so as to make it the

national interoperability operator. Where systems have been built, the skills to run them have not always come with them: UNDP records that considerable capacity building among national stakeholders is still needed to govern the open-source components of the e-ID system, which was built by an external vendor with a local partner.

The pipeline behind all of it is narrow. Tertiary ICT and STEM provision rests on the University of Nouakchott Al Aasriya's Faculté des Sciences et Techniques, the École Supérieure Polytechnique and the Institut Supérieur du Numérique in the public sector, alongside private providers such as Groupe ISI and ESPRI.

Cybersecurity

Mauritania sits in the evolving band of the ITU's 2024 Global Cybersecurity Index, on a legal footing laid a decade ago: Law No. 2016-007 is the country's cybercrime statute, and Mauritania has ratified the African Union's Malabo Convention on cyber security and personal data protection.

The newest additions to the state's electronic reach are investigative powers rather than defences: the investigation provisions of the narcotics bill approved by the Council of Ministers in August 2026 provide for interception of communications, electronic and technical monitoring, and geolocation and technical tracking. Money to build the defensive side is not yet committed, though cybersecurity is one of the components of the digital financing package agreed in principle with the Islamic Development Bank in April 2026.

A decree creating a National Cybersecurity and Electronic Certification Agency, charged with setting up a national response team, was approved by the Council of Ministers on 22 April 2024, and the digital minister discussed a national response team and security operations centre with the United States chargé d'affaires and the firm Cybastion in January 2026, with nothing signed. The project unit issued a national tender on 9 October 2026 to set up the national response team and a security operations centre for the administration's intranet, with bids due 17 November 2026.

DPI

Data Exchange

Since April 2025 a Mauritanian company can be created in a single online transaction that simultaneously enters it in the Registre de Commerce, issues its tax identification number and affiliates it to the Caisse Nationale de Sécurité Sociale, run through the Khidmaty portal and authenticated by the Houwiyeti identity app — the most substantial working exchange of data between Mauritanian administrations, and one built with no national interoperability platform underneath it.

That is the pattern throughout. The population register has offered web APIs since around 2010 that let the electoral commission, mobile operators and financial institutions verify identity in real time, giving partial automated exchange in the absence of a general platform (2022). The legal footing is Décret n° 2022-009 on inter-administration electronic exchange, with a Référentiel Général d'Interopérabilité proposed rather than in place (June 2023). A 2024 scoping study for the digital transformation ministry sets out the missing piece — a General Interoperability Framework and an Interoperability Hub comprising an API gateway, identity and access management and a unified data repository — and names civil-status and identity documents among the first service families to be brought into it.

The design of the planned national address register shows how far the design work runs ahead of delivery: it looks to the Agence Numérique de l'État to host the address database and build an interoperability API, and to the housing and urban planning ministry to update cartographic data so that every parcel receives a digital address, none of it yet operational (2025). Interoperability is an explicit objective of the governing digital strategy and an axis of a

standalone national strategy for open and interoperable data, and unified standards for digital public services were set at a national workshop with German cooperation in March 2025. The personal data protection law of 2017 has still not been brought fully into force, and no dedicated cross-government data-sharing law is in effect (2024).

Digital Identity and CRVS

Biometric identification against the national register is a legal precondition for selling or activating any SIM card in Mauritania, and the regulator, having ordered unidentified SIMs deactivated in October 2023, issued formal notices to Mattel, Mauritel and Chinguitel in January 2026 over their failure to comply.

The register behind that requirement, SIGPTS, launched in 2020 and run by ANRPTS, had enrolled the great majority of the population by May 2025. Enrolment for the biometric register met protests from 2011 under the banner « Touche pas à ma nationalité » over claims that it excluded citizens (2019). The interior minister put more than 5.1 million people on the national register in a parliamentary answer of 18 June 2026, with no denominator or coverage rate beside it, and described enrolment as having become a permanent public service. Décret n° 2021-138 governs the card it issues: a secure contact and contactless-chip document, the official proof of identity and nationality, available voluntarily from age six and compulsory for every Mauritanian of sixteen or over holding a National Identification Number. Fingerprints are captured for the national biometric register, with the Houwiyeti platform adding a facial image for one-to-one matching by smartphone camera with liveness detection. The card is not issued free of charge, and the governing decree requires payment for issuance, replacement or renewal.

Houwiyeti reached the public in January 2024, letting citizens authenticate to government services by facial match against their stored eID over OpenID Connect rather than a password; ANRPTS had launched it in December 2023 for requests for identity and civil status documents. It was built by the Swiss vendor TECH5 with the local firm SmartMS and funded by UNDP, which records that national stakeholders still need considerable capacity building to govern the open-source components, and designed for low-connectivity areas, with offline verification and several credentials on one phone.

No dedicated digital-identity legislation has been enacted: the system rests on decree and civil-registration law written for the biometric card, with legislation for the digital ID left to a future phase (2024). The card is one accepted proof among several for enrolling in public health insurance (2023) and underpins tiered know-your-customer checks at financial institutions without being universally mandatory to open an account (2022). Refugees in the camp and urban caseloads, around 128,000 people by March 2024, are registered by the national registry agency and issued National Identification Numbers, with backlogs remaining. Mauritania is not among the six countries in the ECOWAS and World Bank WURI programme for cross-border identity interoperability (2022).

Digital Payments and Fintech

Mauritania's tax authority runs an online filing and payment system, and use of it collapses at the payment step: among public bodies, 66 are enrolled, 53 file electronically and 3 pay through it (July 2026), and from 1 November 2026 public establishments must invoice, declare and pay through an electronic platform, no invoice being payable unless registered and validated on it. The platform itself, the Système de télédéclaration et télépaiement, is live alongside a separate tele-services portal (2026), while electronic payment of import and export duties remains an unimplemented Trade Facilitation Agreement commitment recorded by the WTO as showing no progress, so digital revenue collection stops short of customs (2026).

Retail rails run through GIMTEL, the interbank card and payments switch established in May 2005 under the aegis of the Banque Centrale de Mauritanie as an economic interest grouping whose members include the central bank, Mauripost and the commercial banks. The central bank opened interbank interoperability between mobile wallet applications through GIMTEL in October 2024, following a project begun in 2021, and a 2025 tender sought the

implementation of an instant payment system enabling interoperability of financial services. Payment infrastructure, that system included, is the second of five objectives in the central bank's National Digital Payment Strategy 2023–2028, issued in September 2024, which also sets out to ease the regulation of payment and electronic money institutions to attract fintech investment and to place governance of the field across the ministries, the central bank and the telecoms regulator. The statutory base beneath all of it is Law No. 2021-014 of 5 July 2021 on electronic payment services and means, published in the Official Gazette of 30 July 2021, under which the central bank's 2022 instruction regulating payment institutions was issued. Cross-border, Mauritania appears neither among PAPSS's live participants nor in its extended network (June 2026); Visa's listing of GIMTEL in its 2025 global registry of approved service providers rests on card-data security certification, not on cross-border instant payment.

The central bank has begun work on a digital currency: it ran a week of tests of a proof of concept in a sandbox environment (September 2026), and no design, participant, pilot date or legal basis has been published.

The demand side is thin. Account ownership at a financial institution or with a mobile-money provider stood at 27.31% of adults aged 15 and over in the 2024 Global Findex fieldwork, up from single-digit mobile money penetration in 2018, and access to banking services scores 13.4 of 100 in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 36th of 54 African states and among the country's ten worst-scoring measures (2023). The Alliance for Financial Inclusion found in 2024 that GIMTEL is not well positioned to serve people of modest means, and that the financial inclusion targets in the National Financial Inclusion Strategy 2023–2028 are not embedded in payment-scheme governance; refugees' access to financial services remains partial, with digitisation and mobile money for that group at an early stage.

Registries

Fewer than half of Mauritanian births were registered by 2021, well down on the middle of the decade before, when 66% of children under five had their birth registered and 40% held a certificate (2015) — against a civil registration system that is the country's best-performing administrative measure in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 75.0 of 100 and 7th of 54 African states, on a score unchanged from 2014.

Civil registration is run by ANRPTS, covers births, marriages, divorces and deaths and is recorded at commune-level Citizen Welcome Centres (2025) — the same agency and the same counters that issue identity documents against the SIGPTS register, leaving registration and identity only partially integrated. Enrolment happens at fixed and mobile reception centres, including missions that travel to villages, where staff key biographic details and capture fingerprints, photograph and signature straight into the national biometric database while applicants still bring paper source documents (2023). A newborn is enrolled free at a reception centre on the health facility's birth extract, within 60 days of birth.

The other registries are uneven. The 2024 presidential register held 1,939,342 voters against a voting-age population of 2,510,244, a coverage rate of 77.2%, compiled as the biometric RAVEL 2023 register, which requires a valid biometric identity card and is deduplicated against the national ID database. A single general Tax Identification Number covers all tax operations, individuals and businesses alike (2025), and a National Social Registry of the poorest households carries social-protection targeting (2024). Consular registration has moved online for the Riyadh mission's zone, through a platform delivering the consular card, travel authorisation, legalisation and repatriation permits without attending a mission, though the consular registration service remains the competent authority for issuing services and updating records.

Land is the weakest. World Bank land governance work finds no national cadastral plan or land register, with formal registration concentrated in urban areas (2025), and the TEHLIL legal cadastre and the electronic land registry set up in Nouakchott in 2014 now sit under a modernisation reform launched in September 2025 and being extended progressively across the country. There is no operational national address register either: terms of reference were

issued in March 2025 for support to MAURIPOST in implementing a georeferenced digital addressing system under the World Bank's WARDIP programme. The digital ministry presented the system on 29 September 2026, with a pilot version expected by the end of the year.

Sectoral management information systems

Mauritania's sectoral information systems digitise above the point of service rather than at it. Health posts keep a paper patient registry and documents that patients carry between visits, and submit their information on paper to health centres, where it is made digital (2025). Education statistics are gathered from above the school too: a two-day workshop in Brakna in April 2025 trained inspectors and regional education staff on the national SIRAGE platform, with field visits to every school to collect the data (2025). Smartphone data capture by community health workers exists as a nine-facility pilot in two districts, an isolated exception rather than a national pattern (2025).

Where systems are being built, they are being built at the centre. The education ministry has been testing a nine-module human-resources system for teachers, covering recruitment, careers, pay and postings, since 2023 (February 2025). The health solidarity fund CNASS launched digital services for policyholders on the Khidmati platform in May 2026, with claims filed online and a 48-hour handling commitment. A National e-Health Strategy for 2024–2030, launched in October 2025, sets out a national vaccination database, an E-CNAM digital health insurance platform and expanded telemedicine. Social protection has the working data spine: the Tekavoul cash-transfer programme identifies and enrols beneficiaries through civil-registration-linked identification drawn from the Social Register.

In revenue and justice the constraint is administrative rather than technical. The tax authority's 2025–2029 strategic plan sets out planned work to interface its information system with other public bodies and to generalise electronic filing and payment. Public financial management has meanwhile been going backwards: budgetary and financial management fell 7.0 points to 59.7 of 100 over 2014–2023 in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, one of the ten most deteriorated Mauritanian measures, and tax and revenue mobilisation fell 2.7 points to 53.8 (2023). The RACHAD electronic expenditure chain has been deployed under the 2021-2025 public financial management strategy, and a EUR 46.3 million World Bank programme appraised in May 2025 makes its interoperability with the tax and investment platforms a results area to 2030. Criminal record certificates went online in March 2025 through the Houwiyeti application, covering national judicial records rather than case management at individual posts: the UN Human Rights Committee noted in 2021 that police records of detainees were poorly maintained (2023). The state news agency reported the Sebkha health centre presented as a pilot that had digitised its patients' records (2022). A news site reported registration and transfer of pupils for the 2026-2027 school year opening on the Siraj platform on 28 September 2026.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Mauritania's Ijraati portal, launched in February 2026, centralises more than 800 administrative procedures in a single directory, under a three-phase roadmap that moves from centralising procedures, to keeping them updated and reliable, to fully digitising the most-used ones inside the Khdamati platform — which places most of the digitisation itself in the future. Already available online are university enrolment at Nouakchott, company registration and investment-code approvals, criminal-record certificates, and vehicle registration through the Digital Road Traffic System (2025).

Three services joined them in 2026. The water utility SNDE's transactions became available remotely, without a branch visit, from 4 August 2026, with its services integrated into the « Mes Services » government portal. Digital consular services for citizens abroad were launched on 9 July 2026 with nine online services in a first phase, and the Riyadh embassy put the consular platform into service for Saudi Arabia, Bahrain and the Maldives later that month. And Mourchid, launched in June 2026, brings public employment, vocational-training and entrepreneurship-support

programmes into a single portal, though it functions mainly as an information and guidance tool with no documented API integration between employment services and the Social Registry or the National Employment Agency database.

The institutional base is thinner than the service layer. UNDP proposed a standing state digital agency, ANETA, under the digital ministry in July 2021, with an e-Cabinet platform and a public-procurement-portal MVP among its quick wins; the digital ministry issued terms of reference in March 2024 for an encrypted platform to be the sole channel between ministers, its source code to be handed to the ministry. Procurement has since moved online: a national portal publishing procurement plans, tender notices and award results opened on 3 December 2024, and the SIGMAP integrated procurement system was in use by 200 contracting authorities and 91 procurement commissions in July 2026, with electronic bid submission still in testing. Public administration is nonetheless Mauritania's second best-scoring governance dimension in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 57.9 of 100 and 20th of 54 African states (2023), and accessibility of public records is its fastest-improving transparency measure, even as the country sits in the bottom fifth of the UN's 2024 E-Government Development Index. The reach of central systems is limited: of 642 legally constituted public bodies, 339 are active with the tax administration and around twenty are not registered in the national taxpayer register at all (July 2026). A national government cloud launched in June 2026 gives the estate somewhere to run. The national solidarity agency launched a unified digital platform for social assistance, opening with transport costs for 11,656 pupils and students from households in the social registry, verified by facial recognition (2026).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Digitalising territorial administration reached the table on 13 August 2026, when the minister delegate to the interior minister presented the Diwan territorial-administration system, whose integration with the Khidmaty services platform is under way, to a German delegation comprising the embassy chargé d'affaires and GIZ, as part of decentralisation cooperation. Otherwise digital-government activity is concentrated at central-government level, in a country where much of the population lives in rural areas with thinner connectivity and public-service infrastructure (2024). Where capacity is built below the centre it is to feed central systems rather than to run local ones: workshops in Brakna and Hodh Charghi in April 2025 were aimed at regional capacity to operate the SIRAGE education platform and to organise school-visit data-collection missions, not at digitising the schools themselves. Rural representation and participation, by contrast, is one of Mauritania's stronger and faster-improving governance measures (2023).

Rural digital data capture

In rural Mauritania the record is made on paper and digitised a level above it: health posts keep a paper patient registry and submit their information on paper to health centres, where it is made digital (2025). The same shape holds in schooling, where inspectors and regional education staff trained on the national SIRAGE platform in Brakna made field visits to every school to collect its data (2025); in policing, police records of detainees were found poorly maintained (2023).

The exceptions are narrow and deliberate. Smartphone capture by community health workers runs as a small NGO-supported pilot rather than a national pattern (2025). Civil status is where digital capture does reach the village: ANRPTS reception centres, including missions that travel to villages, enter biographic details and capture fingerprints, photograph and signature directly into the national biometric database at the counter, with applicants still bringing paper source documents (2023). The e-ID pilot was built for the same conditions, with offline

verification and several credentials on one phone, and designed for rural users (2024). What holds it back is physical: electricity access is heavily skewed towards towns (2023), and formal land registration is concentrated in urban areas, with no national cadastral plan or land register behind it (2025).

Rural governance itself is not uniformly weak. Rural representation and participation rose 15.8 points over 2014-2023 to 74.2 of 100, 16th of 54 African states, among both Mauritania's best-scoring and most improved measures (2023), and rural economy support rose 12.6 points to 66.6 and rural land and water access 7.7 points to 63.8 (2023). The rural economy sub-category nonetheless fell 4.9 points to 55.9 of 100, 32nd of 54, one of two sub-categories pulling against the country's overall improvement (2023), and market access is the sole cause of that decline, now among the weakest measures in the country's profile.

Technology

AI

Mauritania has a national artificial-intelligence strategy dated 2024, drafted by the digital transformation ministry in April 2024 for 2024–2029 around five strategic priorities, twelve objectives and thirty measures, with sector projects from health and education to fisheries, energy and defence.

Commercial interest so far comes from the mobile market: the operator that launched the country's first 5G network in August 2026 presented it as groundwork for AI, cloud computing and connected-device services in sectors from health and education to mining and finance.

ICT Industry

Mauritania's rules for business and competition are among the weakest in Africa and have not moved: 34.4 of 100, and 48th of 54 states, in the 2024 Ibrahim Index (2023), a score essentially flat across the decade, inside a wider business and labour environment that lost 2.2 points over the same period to reach 40.3 (2023).

The domestic technology industry working inside those rules is small and thinly financed (2026). The Startup Act bill presented in September 2023 offered the sector customs and VAT relief on imported equipment and a subsidy towards the cost of protecting intellectual property.

Physical distribution is a hard constraint on any of it: the shipping and postal network sits among Mauritania's ten worst-scoring measures in the same index, and it and the transport network both lost ground over the decade to 2023.

Larger technology supply is substantially foreign. The operator behind the newest mobile network is a subsidiary of Sudan's Sudatel and has set out an investment plan for 2027–2030 covering network expansion, fibre and national data centres, while Nouakchott's urban security and monitoring system was funded by a Chinese government grant in 2021 and contracted to a Chinese builder.

Innovation ecosystem

Mauritania's innovation economy is small and grant-dependent: no venture capital fund is headquartered in the country, angel activity is minimal, and start-up financing comes largely as donor and government grants (2026). The country placed 126th on WIPO's Global Innovation Index in 2024, in the bottom quartile.

The policy answer is the Startup Act, promulgated in January 2024. As presented in September 2023 and framed within the Agenda Digital 2022–2025, the bill was built around a merit-based start-up label carrying benefits for five years, awarded by a labelling committee with a national body to run the scheme. Labelled firms were to get a three-

year exemption from the patente business tax and partial corporate-tax relief across the label period, relief on employer and employee social contributions, a preferential margin in public procurement, international market-access programmes and a right of access to open data, with tax relief for the support structures around them and a technology-innovation hub. The finance side of the bill added investor tax relief, foreign-currency accounts and a state-backed start-up fund alongside a guarantee fund. The ministry attached targets of a few hundred labelled firms and several thousand jobs over the five years, and a markedly better Global Innovation Index placing by 2028.

The support structures that exist are few and concentrated in Nouakchott. Hadina RIMTIC, an incubator founded in 2014, had incubated five start-ups and pre-incubated 26 more (2023) and runs recurring programmes including the MauriAppChallenge, with InnovRim/SahelFabLab operating as a second fab lab and incubator.

Capacity

Literacy

Education is jointly the second worst-ranked of Mauritania's governance dimensions in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, scoring 34.5 of 100 for 2023 and placing the country 48th of 54 African states — and that is after a 5.9-point gain across the decade to 2023.

The decade's movement sits unevenly under that headline. Equality in education rose 11.2 points to 41.5 and completion 9.8 points to 36.4, so the system has become fairer and better at holding on to the pupils it enrols. Enrolment itself barely moved, at 31.5 and 38th of 54, up a tenth of a point over ten years, and quality reached only 28.3, 40th of 54 and up 2.1 points (2023). The gains are in distribution and retention; the two measures that set the ceiling on adult literacy have stayed where they were.

Enrolment, attendance and transition statistics are compiled through the national education management information system, but in rural primary schools pupil and attendance records are kept on paper and reach the platform only when regional inspectors collect them on periodic field visits and enter them at district or regional level (2025). The numbers that describe the weakest part of the system are therefore the ones assembled furthest from it.

Training and skills

Mauritania's own government has put the limit on people rather than equipment: the national IPv6 transition strategy weights its costing towards human resources, on the stated ground that most installed kit already supports the protocol. That is an unusually direct admission for a technical migration plan, and it points at the same shortage every other digital programme in the country runs into.

Tertiary provision in ICT and STEM is concentrated in a small number of institutions — the public university's science and engineering faculties, a polytechnic school and a dedicated digital institute, alongside a handful of private providers (2024). Outside the formal system the pipeline narrows further, to a few incubators and fab labs: Hadina RIMTIC, a Nouakchott incubator founded in 2014 that runs recurring programmes including the MauriAppChallenge, and InnovRim/SahelFabLab as a second (2023).

Public-sector skills work has been narrow and mostly tied to particular systems. Training in April 2025 was aimed at equipping regional education staff to operate the SIRAGE platform and to run the school-visit missions that feed it, rather than at putting recording tools into schools. On the labour-market side, the Mourchid portal, launched in June 2026, draws public employment, vocational-training and entrepreneurship programmes into a single place, working as a guide to what exists rather than joining up the services behind it.

Research institutions

Mauritania had no public research institution or national research programme working on digital, data or statistical questions as at September 2026.

Inclusion

Access to services

Inclusion and equality scored 25.2 of 100 in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 48th of 54 African states in 2023 despite a 7.0-point gain over the decade, with equal access to public services at 28.8 — 40th, and up just 1.3 points — and equal socioeconomic opportunity at 18.9, 49th and among the country's ten worst-scoring measures. The gain has come almost entirely from somewhere other than who can reach a public service.

The fund meant to close that gap is itself being rebuilt. Mauritania's Council of Ministers moved in July 2026 to replace the 2020 decree governing the Fonds d'accès universel aux services, and its stated grounds were that six years of application had exposed shortcomings in how the fund's object is defined, in how its resources are mobilised, distributed and allocated, and in the absence of a clear framework for folding it into the state's budgetary and accounting system. The communiqué did not set out what the replacement provides, so the instrument meant to extend service to unserved communities is being rebuilt to terms nobody outside government has seen.

Individual services are nonetheless being put online. Water utility transactions moved onto the « Mes Services » portal from 4 August 2026, and a consular platform opened for Mauritanians in Saudi Arabia, Bahrain and the Maldives. Documentation rules are not the obstacle they often are elsewhere: health insurance enrolment accepts several proofs of identity, with equivalents for migrants and refugees. Money is. Refugees reach financial services only partly, through work such as that with the Djikké cooperative serving urban caseloads, with digitisation and mobile money for them at an early stage, and the national payments switch was judged ill-suited to serving people of modest means.

Digital divides

About 55% of Mauritania's population did not use the internet in 2024, which puts most of the country outside the services being designed for it. Price explains part of that. A 5 GB mobile data plan cost 2.94% of GNI per capita in 2025, against the 2% international affordability benchmark, even though an entry-level 1 GB basket sits within that threshold and a fixed connection costs many times more. Affordability holds only at the smallest package a household can buy; it fails the moment use rises to anything a family or a small business would need, and it fails entirely for a fixed line.

The decade's gains have been in voice and coverage rather than in what people can do online. Mobile communications is among the country's ten most improved measures in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, while access to internet and computers moved far less over the same years. The pattern in schooling runs the same way: equality in education and completion both improved over the decade while enrolment stayed flat and quality barely moved, so the pool of people equipped to use a connection has grown more slowly than the network reaching them.

The sharpest divide is geographic. Electricity access is overwhelmingly urban, and rural Mauritania carries comparatively limited connectivity and public-service infrastructure — a household without power is not a household a mobile network can serve, whatever the coverage map says.

Data

National statistics

The capacity of Mauritania's statistical system rose 11.6 points over the decade to 2023, reaching 55.7 of 100 in the 2024 Ibrahim Index and 20th place of 54 African states — one of the country's larger administrative gains of the period.

The improvement is unevenly spread. Across the five pillars of the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators, Mauritania scored above 89 per cent on the use of data but only 20 to 49 per cent on data sources in 2023, with data services and infrastructure in the 50 to 69 band and data products at 70 to 89. It is the collection of source material, not its processing or its use, that constrains the system.

That shows in the collection calendar. A population census has been held within the last ten years, but neither an agricultural census nor an economic or business census in the last twenty. The survey programme leans the same way: three or more health surveys, two household surveys, two labour surveys and one agricultural survey in the decade to 2023, and no business or establishment survey at all. The productive economy is the part of the country least often measured.

Gaps of that kind carry into the comparative record. The 2024 Ibrahim Index has no data for Mauritania on 15 of its 96 indicators, among them human resources in education and every one of the index's public perception measures, so the country is scored on a smaller instrument than its neighbours are.

Two external pressures bear on what the statistics agency can produce. An Agence Française de Développement grant channelled through UN Women is modernising the data systems of the national statistics institutes of Mauritania, Senegal and Chad to improve gender-disaggregated data (2024). At the other end of the pipeline, rural health posts keep handwritten registers, with paper summaries sent up to district centres for entry into DHIS2 (2025), so primary-care statistics are digitised above the point of care rather than at it.

Open data

Mauritania published 24 open datasets from four providers as at June 2023, against Tunisia's 2,346 datasets from 161 providers, and the government's own open-data strategy, which benchmarks the country against Morocco, Senegal and Tunisia, places Mauritania last on every measure it publishes.

Publication runs through mauritania.opendataforafrica.org, the channel operated by the statistics agency ANSADE. The strategy rests on three axes: an interoperability framework among government entities, open-data governance aligned with Open Government Partnership principles, and use of open data for innovation — while Mauritania is not an OGP member, where all three of its chosen comparators are (June 2023). The strategy provided for designing and implementing a national open-data portal, and the WARDIP procurement plan of December 2025 scheduled consultant selection for a national portal at data.gov.mr for March and April 2026.

Openness varies sharply by domain. In the 2024 Open Data Inventory, balance of payments scores 7.5 out of ten and money and banking 5.5, while government finance, labour and prices sit at 4 and national accounts and international trade at 3. Among social statistics, population and vital statistics lead at 5.5 and poverty and reproductive health at 4.5, with gender statistics at 2.5 and crime and justice at 2 the weakest categories in the assessment. Environmental statistics run between 3 and 4.5, energy strongest and agriculture and pollution weakest. The pattern is that what a central bank or a demographic survey produces gets published, and what a line ministry holds does not.

The 2024 Ibrahim Index separates what citizens can reach from what the state chooses to release. Accessibility of public records scores 24.7 of 100 and ranks 34th of 54 African states, the fastest-improving of the country's transparency measures with an 11.9-point gain over the decade, while disclosure of public records is among Mauritania's ten worst measures at 10.1 of 100 and 50th of 54 (2023). The digital ministry's own page on the Startup Act shows the habit at close range: it names and dates the law but carries no text of the instrument.

Use of satellite data

Mauritania's telecoms regulator ARE had selected three companies to provide satellite telecommunications services in the country by July 2026, after a tender launched in January.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

Neither the United States government nor any global cloud provider had an established presence in Mauritania's digital sector as at September 2026. Talks between the digital minister, the United States chargé d'affaires and the firm Cybastion in January 2026 on a national cyber response capability produced no signed agreement.

China activities

China's one substantial intervention in Mauritania's digital estate builds surveillance capacity for the police: a 2021 grant agreement worth MRU 629.4 million, about US$15 million at the time, drawn from an Economic and Technical Cooperation Agreement, funding an Urban Security and Monitoring System for the General Directorate of National Security in Nouakchott. The design runs to 316 surveillance cameras extensible to 1,000 observation points, a two-storey unified command centre, three regional security service buildings and 34 police observation posts — a state-security build, not a service-delivery one, and separate in kind from the connectivity and public-administration work European lenders have paid for.

Chinese public money accounts for one of the eleven external financing commitments on the record for Mauritania's digital estate, against three apiece from the World Bank and the European Investment Bank. On count of commitments, China is a minor financier of the sector and a singular one in what it has chosen to fund.

EU activities

Europe has paid for Mauritania's physical layer, and the clearest instance is the national data centre in Nouakchott, inaugurated in May 2025 on a EUR 15 million European Investment Bank loan, certified Tier III by the Uptime Institute and operated by International Mauritanian Telecommunications. Undersea the pattern is the same: the EIB signed a EUR 25 million loan in December 2020 for the country's first direct high-speed fibre link to Europe and West Africa, running to 2025; the EllaLink connection project was launched at Nouadhibou in July 2025; and Mauritania is a landing country on the MEDUSA system connecting Portugal to North and West Africa, backed by an EIB loan and a European Union investment grant.

Bilateral European programmes cover the softer side. Germany's BMZ is funding a EUR 4 million digital transformation programme, DIGITAL-Y, running 2024 to 2027, aimed jointly at the state and the digital sector and framed around a young, largely unemployed population with limited access to public services in health and education; German cooperation also sat behind the national workshop held in March 2025 to set unified standards for digital public services and improve interoperability between government systems. France's development agency has put a EUR 2.5 million grant, channelled through UN Women as phase 2 of the Women Count programme, into modernising the data systems of the national statistics institutes of Mauritania, Senegal and Chad (2024) to improve the production and use of gender-disaggregated data.

The European Investment Bank is, with the World Bank, one of the two most frequent financiers of Mauritania's digital estate, three commitments each of the eleven on record, and all three of the EIB's are submarine-cable connectivity. Add the single commitments from Germany's development ministry and the French development agency and European institutions account for five of the eleven — the largest bloc, and the one that has shaped what the country's international bandwidth and hosting look like.

Gulf/UAE activities

Mauritania and the Islamic Development Bank signed an agreement in principle in April 2026 on a digital transformation financing package covering digital infrastructure and equipment, cybersecurity, interoperability and system modernisation, and digital skills, connectivity and innovation.

India activities

India had no established role in Mauritania's digital sector as at September 2026.

Digital sovereignty

Mauritania's state servers now run at home: the digital transformation minister told the National Assembly on 2 July 2026 that all public-administration servers had been moved into the national data centre, and that the national cloud launched days earlier ends the state's reliance on foreign hosting platforms. The cloud was inaugurated at the Nouakchott data centre on 29 June 2026 with World Bank support through WARDIP.

Where data may go abroad is set by the data protection authority rather than by a localisation law: its deliberation 005/2025 makes any use of a foreign cloud by a public or private body subject to prior authorisation and to contract terms on returning and deleting the data.

Operation sits with a consortium rather than a ministry. The state company SDIN is to own the national backbone and its technical building and to delegate their operation, maintenance and sale to the International Mauritania Telecom consortium, which also runs the national data centre. The terms on which that operating arrangement governs data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026, and an MP asked on 13 September 2026 for the data centre contract, which he put at more than five billion old ouguiya, and the RIAD administrative-network contract to be published and independently audited.

The identity layer is partly open. For the Houwiyeti digital-ID pilot, the local firm SmartMS built the back end and identity provider around TECH5's face-matching technology, and TECH5 contributed the source code of the customised solution to the open-source MOSIP platform. Whether the state holds the source code for the SIGPTS population register that ANRPTS runs, or needs a vendor to change it, was not on record as at September 2026.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

EDITION	**2026-10-18**
COMPILED	By Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/MRT/MRT-status-2026-10-18.pdf
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